

Mandarin, Step by Step, Character by Character

A composition-driven introduction to standard Mandarin

Adhithya Rajasekaran

Starter edition — seven short lessons in one cumulative chapter.

Copyright © Adhithya Rajasekaran. Licensed under Creative Commons
Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International (CC BY-SA 4.0). Chinese is set
in a subset of Noto Sans SC (SIL Open Font License).

How to use this starter edition

Begin with no assumed Chinese. Each section takes one small expression, teaches only the characters and sounds needed for it, shows what those characters are built from, and ends with a short retrieval prompt. There is no character list to memorise first.

Two things about Mandarin will be new to a reader coming from a European language, and this book meets both in its first chapter rather than deferring them. The first is that Chinese is written in *characters*, not letters: each one is an evenly sized block built from smaller recurring components, and words are one or more of those blocks. The second is that *pitch is part of the word*. Said on a high flat note, a falling note, or a low dipping one, the same syllable is three different words. That is not emphasis; it is as much a part of the word as a consonant.

This book is also honest about one thing it cannot do. A related language would let a new word be attached to English words the reader already owns through a shared ancestor — Spanish *gracias* to *grace* and *gratitude*. Chinese and English share no ancestor, so there are no cousins to show, and inventing some would be worse than having none. What replaces them here is the composition of the characters themselves: 好 is 女, woman, beside 子, child. That is a real and visible structure, and it does help — but it anchors a new word to knowledge you are acquiring in the same breath rather than to knowledge you already had, so it is a weaker hook than a shared ancestor would give. Where a component gloss is a traditional memory picture rather than settled history, this book says so.

Romanization (pinyin) stays beside the characters in this starter edition and will fade gradually. The variety taught is standard Mandarin in simplified characters; traditional characters are a labelled future edition, not a silent substitute.

Contents

How to use this starter edition	iii
1 Nǐ Hǎo — Hello, Character by Character	1
1.1 mā má mǎ mà	1
1.2 nǐ	2
1.3 hǎo	4
1.4 nǐ hǎo	5
1.5 ní hǎo	7
1.6 hào	8
1.7 Practice	9
2 Reading the Greeting — One Piece at a Time	11
2.1 rén	11
2.2 rén (as a component)	12
2.3 ěr	13
2.4 nǐ	14
2.5 nǚ	16
2.6 zǐ	17
2.7 hǎo	18
Pronunciation & Character Guide	21
Glossary	25
Review Questions	27
Answer Key	29
Sources for this starter edition	31
Index	33

Chapter 1

Nǐ Hǎo — Hello, Character by Character

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 👁️ eyes (2) 🖐️ Hands-free start: all 7 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can greet someone in Mandarin and answer when greeted, reading both characters unaided and saying the greeting with the tone a speaker actually uses rather than the one the dictionary prints.

A two-line meeting in which both voices say the same word — read from the characters alone, with the first third tone raised by sandhi.

1.1 mā má mǎ mà — one syllable, four words

Nothing to recall yet. Before the first Chinese word arrives, one thing your voice is about to be asked to do that English never asks of it.

The sounds and tones in this word

In English, pitch carries mood. *Really.* and *Really?* are the same word, said two ways.

In Mandarin, **pitch is part of the word**, exactly the way a consonant is. Take the syllable *ma* and give it four different pitches and you get four unrelated words:

- **mā** — held high and flat, one steady note. *Mother.*
- **má** — rising, like the pitch on a surprised English “huh?”. *Hemp.*

- **mǎ** — dipping low, a little creaky. *Horse*.
- **mà** — falling sharply, like a clipped “No!”. *To scold*.

There is a fifth, the **neutral** tone: short, light, no mark written at all. The accent over the vowel is how the romanization writes the tone: a flat bar in **mā**, a rising stroke in **má**, a hook in **mǎ**, a falling stroke in **mà**. The Chinese characters themselves record no tone anywhere, so the accent is a teaching aid, not part of the writing.

Say all four in order now, slowly: **mā, má, mǎ, mà**. [REPEAT x2]

Your turn

- *Say it:* **mā** high and flat, then **mà** falling — hear how far apart they are
- *Answer:* if you change the pitch of a Mandarin syllable, what changes?

Before you move on

Which accent tells you to dip low? (The hook, as in **mǎ**.) Does changing a Mandarin tone change how you feel about a word, or which word it is? (Which word it is.)

Source: the tone inventory this track keeps

1.2 你 — “you”, and the first character

Say the four tones on *ma* once, in order. Hold the third one — low and dipping. The first Chinese word carries exactly that pitch.

The sounds and tones in this word

nǐ. The *n* is the English *n*; the *i* is the *ee* of “see”. The hook over it is the **third tone**: start low, stay low, let it creak. [REPEAT x2]

Script — 你, and the person hiding on its left

Chinese is not written with letters. It is written with **characters**, each an evenly sized square block, and each block built from smaller recurring pieces

called **components**.

你 has two of them, left and right:

亻 + 尔 → 你

亻 is the “person” component. On its own the character for a person is 人 — two legs walking. Push it to the left edge of a block and it is squashed upright into 亻: one short slant over one vertical. Same piece, standing sideways to make room.

尔 on the right is there for its *sound*, not its meaning. Chinese builds most of its characters this way — one component pointing at the meaning, another at the pronunciation.

Stroke order is a real, taught system here: top before bottom, left before right. So 亻 first, then 尔.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

你 *nǐ* — **you**, addressing one person.

Here this book has to be honest with you. A related language lets a new word be anchored to English words you already own through a shared ancestor — Spanish *gracias* to *grace* and *gratitude*, all from Latin *gratia*. **Chinese shares no ancestor with English.** There is no cousin web for *nǐ*, and inventing one would be worse than having none.

What replaces it is what you just read: the character is itself decomposable, and its pieces mean things. 你 carries a person on its left because it is about a person. That is the hook — not history you share with English, but structure you can see.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **nǐ** — low and dipping, not flat
- *Read it*: 你 — name its left piece, then its right piece

Before you move on

Which component of 你 tells you the word is about a person? (亻.)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

1.3 好 — “good”, and what replaces etymology here

Say the word for “you” without looking. Which of its two components is the person? Now hold that low, dipping pitch — the next word wants the same one.

The sounds and tones in this word

hǎo. The *h* is a little rougher than English *h*, scraped at the back of the mouth. The *ao* is one gliding vowel, the *ow* of “how”. The hook accent is the same third tone you already met: low, dipping, creaky. [REPEAT x2]

Script — 好, a woman beside a child

Two components again, side by side:

女 + 子 → 好

女 on the left is the character for “woman”: a crossing stroke, a curved leg, a horizontal through the middle. 子 on the right is “child”: a hooked top, a hooked vertical, a horizontal arm. Left before right, as always.

Notice what just happened. 女 and 子 are not letters spelling out the sound *hǎo* — neither is pronounced anything like it. They are whole characters with their own meanings, reused as building blocks.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

好 *hǎo* — **good**, and also **well**.

A woman beside a child, and the character means “good”. That picture is the hook — and it stands in for the cousin web that a related language would supply, because **Chinese and English share no ancestor** and there is no honest chain from *hǎo* to any English word. Two cautions, because a memory aid that pretends to be history rots:

- “Woman + child = good” is the **traditional gloss**. It is genuinely useful for remembering the shape, but palaeographers do not all accept it as the historical origin; some read 子 as a phonetic element instead. A picture that helps, not a proven derivation.

- Component glosses are hooks, not translations. 好 does not “mean” woman-child. It means good.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **hǎo** — low and dipping, the *ow* of “how”
- *Read it:* 好 — name its left component, then its right one
- *Answer:* why does this track use component pictures instead of English cousins?

Before you move on

What does 好 mean? (Good, or well.) Is its woman-and-child picture a proven etymology? (No — a traditional and useful gloss, disputed as history.)

Source: Unicode Han database, character 好

1.4 你好 — the greeting, assembled from two things you already have

Two characters, both already yours. Say the one that means “you”. Say the one that means “good”. Now put them in that order and you have said hello — but say it slowly for one more moment, because the tones are about to do something.

The exchange

你好 *nǐ hǎo!* Hello.

你好 *nǐ hǎo!* Hello.

The greeting and its answer are the same word. Say it to one person you have just met, at any hour of the day.

Grammar Lens — a word can be more than one character

English counts a word in **letters**. Chinese does not have letters, so the tempting guess is that it counts a word in **characters** — one character, one word. That guess is wrong, and correcting it early saves

a great deal of confusion.

A character writes one **syllable** and usually one **meaningful piece**.

A **word** is one or more of those pieces:

- 你 — one character, one word: *you*
- 好 — one character, one word: *good*
- 你好 — two characters, still **one word**: *hello*

Nobody hearing 你好 parses it as “you good”, any more than an English speaker hears “good” and “bye” inside *goodbye*. The pieces are visible, which makes the word easy to remember; the whole is what it means.

Why it's said this way

你好 is safe, neutral, and understood everywhere — which is exactly why a course teaches it first. But it is worth knowing that it is used less freely than English “hello”. Between people who already know each other, a Mandarin speaker is more likely to open with a small situational remark than with 你好 at all. Reserve it for meeting someone, and you will sound right.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **nǐ hǎo** — greeting someone you have just met
- *Say it:* **nǐ hǎo** — answering that same greeting
- *Answer:* how many characters is this word, and how many words is it?

Before you move on

Which character comes first, and what does it mean on its own?

(你, “you”.) Is 你好 one word or two? (One.)

Source: Unicode Han database, characters 你 and 好

1.5 ní hǎo — why the greeting is not said the way it is written

Say the greeting once, slowly, giving both syllables the low dipping third tone you were taught. It should feel awkward in the mouth. That awkwardness is the whole lesson.

Grammar Lens — one rule, and it is not optional

When two third tones come one after the other, the first is spoken as a second (rising) tone.

So the greeting, written **nǐ hǎo**, is actually said **ní hǎo** — the first syllable climbs instead of dipping. [REPEAT x2]

Nothing about this shows in the writing. Dictionaries print **nǐ hǎo**, because that is the citation tone each word carries on its own, and the characters 你好 never change at all. A learner who trusts only what is written will say the commonest greeting in the language wrong every time.

Why does it happen? Two dipping tones in a row would need the voice to sink, climb, sink and climb again inside a fifth of a second. Speakers do not do that; the first one gives way. This is a real rule of the sound system, not a sloppy shortcut, and every native speaker applies it without thinking.

Compare it to what English does with “*the*”: written one way, said *thuh* before a consonant and *thee* before a vowel, and no English speaker thinks of that as two words. The difference is that here the change lands on **pitch** — the same property that distinguishes one word from another.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **ní hǎo** — first syllable rising, second dipping
- *Say it:* it again, at speaking speed, without the pause between them
- *Answer:* which spelling changes when the rule applies — pinyin, characters, or neither?

Before you move on

Two third tones meet. What happens to the first? (It rises.) What happens to the characters? (Nothing.)

Source: Chinese Text Project, on tone in Mandarin

1.6 好 again — proof, on a character you own, that tone is the word

Name the character built from a woman and a child, and say what it means. Hold its tone: low and dipping.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

The very same character, 好, has a second reading — and the only thing that separates the two is the tone:

- 好 *hǎo*, dipping third tone — **good**
- 好 *hào*, sharply falling fourth tone — **to be fond of, to like**

Same strokes. Same components. Same shape on the page. Two words. This is the cleanest proof available of what the first lesson claimed. Tone is not decoration on a word; it is *inside* the word, doing the job a consonant does in English. Change *hǎo* to *hào* and you have not said “good” with feeling — you have said a different word, the way *bat* and *pat* are different words.

The two readings are related in meaning, and the relation is a good hook: what is **good** is what one is **fond of**. That is a link inside Chinese, between two readings of one character. It is not a link to English. There is none.

You are not asked to produce **hào** yet. Recognising it is the point: when a familiar character turns up wearing an unfamiliar tone, the tone is telling you this is a different word.

Your turn

- *Answer:* **hǎo** or **hào** — which one means “good”?
- *Answer:* what changed between them, and what stayed the same?

- *Answer:* which two components is this character built from?

Before you move on

One character carried two words today. What told them apart?
(Only the tone.)

Source: Unicode Han database, character 好

1.7 Practice — greet someone, and be greeted back

Retrieve the two words separately first: the one meaning “you”, then the one meaning “good”. Do not run them together yet.

The exchange

A: 你好 *nǐ hǎo!* B: 你好 *nǐ hǎo!*

Two lines, one word, both voices. Every piece is already yours: the characters from their own lessons, the meaning from the greeting lesson, the rising first syllable from the sandhi rule. Nothing new is hiding here.

Say A’s line, pause, then answer as B. [REPEAT x2]

What you’ve built this chapter

Four things, and only one of them is vocabulary:

- 你 is 亻 plus 尔; 好 is 女 beside 子. Characters are built from parts.
- Those parts are the memory hook this track uses, because Chinese and English share no ancestor and therefore no cousin web.
- 你好 is two characters and one word. Characters are not letters.
- Pitch is part of the word, and a neighbouring word can change it without changing a stroke.

Your turn

- *Say it:* greet someone you have just met

- *Say it:* answer that greeting
- *Read it:* 你好 aloud from the characters alone, with no pinyin

Before you move on

Run both lines once more. If the first syllable dips instead of rising, go back to the sandhi lesson only — not to the whole chapter.

Source: Unicode Han database, characters 你 and 好

Chapter 2

Reading the Greeting — One Piece at a Time

Modes: ✓ pen (7) ⇌ Hands-free start: none of the 7 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can write each component the greeting's two characters are built from, and then assemble both characters from those pieces rather than recalling them as whole shapes.

The second assembly, built from two components the reader wrote individually a moment earlier — and a caution that the memorable story about why it means what it means is a story, not a source.

2.1 人 — two strokes, and a person walking

You have heard Mandarin pitch. Now you meet the writing, and this book will hand it to you **one piece at a time** — never a character you have not been shown the parts of first.

This is the whole first piece:

人

Two strokes. That is the entire character.

Script — the shape

人 *rén* means **person**.

Look at it before you read another word about it. A stroke leaning down-left, a stroke leaning down-right, meeting at the top. **It is a figure standing on two legs, seen from the side.** You are not being asked to take that on faith — the oldest surviving forms of this character, scratched into ox bone three thousand years ago, are recognisably a standing person, and the two legs are the part that lasted.

Write it in this order, and the order is not a suggestion:

1. the **left** stroke, from the top down to the lower left — a falling sweep
2. the **right** stroke, starting near the top of the first and pressing down to the lower right

Left before right. Almost every character you meet will obey it, and it is worth meeting here — on a character with two strokes — rather than later on one with fifteen.

The pitch is **second tone**: *rén* rises, like the end of an English question.

Your turn

- *Write it*: 人 — left stroke first, then right. Say *rén* as you finish it.
- *Say it*: **rén**, rising

Before you move on

Which stroke goes first — the one leaning left, or the one leaning right? (The **left**.)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

2.2 人 — the same person, standing sideways

Write the two-stroke character for *person* once, from memory. Left stroke, then right.

Script — one character, two postures

Every Chinese character is written inside an **evenly sized square block** — whether it has two strokes or twenty, it occupies the same footprint. That one fact drives everything you are about to see.

Because when two pieces have to share a block, one of them must get out of the way. Here is what *person* looks like when it moves to the left edge to make room:

亻

Still two strokes. Still the same piece. But the wide-legged stance has been pulled upright into **one short slant on top of one long vertical**, narrow enough that something else can sit beside it.

This is not a different character. It is the same one, squashed. Chinese does this constantly, and the squashed forms are called **components**. When you see 亻 at the left edge of a block, the character is telling you: *this word is about a person*.

Write it:

1. the **short slant**, down-left, at the top 2. the **long vertical**, dropping from the middle of that slant

Top before bottom — the second of the two rules.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 人, then 亻 beside it. Notice you did not learn a new piece — you learned a new **posture**.
- *Notice:* 亻 is tall and thin because it is only using the left half of its square.

Before you move on

Why does *person* change shape at all? (To leave room in the square for whatever stands beside it.)

Source: Unicode CJK Radicals Supplement chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

2.3 尔 — a piece that is there for its sound

The narrow upright person — draw it once. Short slant, long vertical.

Script — the other kind of component

So far a component has meant something: the person piece says *this is about a person*. Here is a component that works the other way.

尔

尔 ěr. Five strokes: a short slant across the top, a broad cover beneath it, then a small stroke each side of a central vertical that finishes with a hook.

Now the part that matters, and it is the single most useful fact about Chinese writing:

Most characters are built from one component pointing at the MEANING and another pointing at the SOUND. When 尔 turns up inside a character, it is usually there because the word sounds something like ěr — not because the word has anything to do with what 尔 means on its own.

That is a strange idea when your reading habits come from an alphabet, where every piece is sound and none is meaning. It is also a relief: it means characters are not arbitrary pictures to be memorised whole. They are **built**, from a small stock of pieces, and once you know the pieces you can often guess both halves of a character you have never seen.

The pitch is **third tone**: ěr dips low.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 尔 — top slant, cover, then the middle with its hook last
- *Say it:* ěr, low and dipping

Before you move on

Two kinds of component, then. One tells you what a word is **about**; the other tells you roughly how it **sounds**. Which kind is 尔?

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

2.4 Putting two pieces together — and reading the result

Two pieces, both already yours. Draw them side by side:

亻 尔

The narrow person on the left. The five-stroke sound piece on the right.

Script — the assembly

Push them into one square block and you have written a character:

亻 + 尔 → 你

Read it the way you now know how to read it, half at a time:

- the **left** half is the person component. So this word is **about a person**.
- the **right** half is the sound piece ěr. So this word **sounds something like ěr**.

The word is *nǐ*. And that is the honest state of the sound half — *nǐ* and *ěr* are close, not identical. **A sound component gets you into the neighbourhood, not to the door.** Sound components were chosen over two thousand years of pronunciation change, and the pronunciations moved out from under them. Expect a hint, and you will be right most of the time; expect a rule, and Chinese will embarrass you weekly.

Write it left before right, exactly as you learned each half:

1. 亻 — short slant, long vertical 2. 尔 — top slant, cover, then the middle and its hook

Seven strokes in total, and you did not memorise a single new one.

What you've built

Stop and take the measure of what just happened, because it is the reason this book teaches script this way.

You have not been shown a picture and asked to remember it. You were given two pieces, one at a time, and then shown that a character is what you get when they share a square. **The next character works the same way, and so does the one after that.** There are only a few hundred components in common use, and they recombine — which is what makes several thousand characters a climb rather than a cliff.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 你 — left half first, complete, then the right half
- *Read it:* cover the right half. What does the left half alone tell you?

Before you move on

Two pieces, one block, and a character you can take apart again whenever you need to. Which half would you look at to guess the pronunciation?

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

2.5 女 — three strokes, seated

One character so far assembles from two known halves. Draw it, and name each half as you write it.

Script — the shape

A new piece, and like the first one it is old enough to still look like what it meant:

女

女 *nǚ* — **woman**. Three strokes.

The oracle-bone form is a **kneeling or seated figure with the arms crossed in front**. The modern character keeps the crossing: that long horizontal running right across the middle is the arms, and the two curving strokes beneath and around it are the folded body. It has straightened out over three thousand years, but nothing has been added or taken away.

Write it in this order:

1. the stroke that starts upper-right and **curves down and left** 2. the stroke that crosses it, going **down-left then flicking right** 3. the **long horizontal**, last, sweeping across both

That third stroke going last is worth noticing — a long horizontal that crosses everything else usually waits until the end.

The pitch is **third tone**, and the vowel is the rounded *ü*: say *ee* and then push your lips into a whistle without changing the tongue.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 女 — and let the crossing bar go last
- *Say it:* **nǚ**, low and dipping, lips rounded

Before you move on

Which stroke comes last, and why? (The **long horizontal** — a bar that crosses the whole character usually waits.)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

2.6 子 — three strokes, a child

Three strokes, crossing bar last. Draw the seated figure you met a moment ago.

Script — the shape

子

子 *zǐ* — **child**. Three strokes again, and again a figure you can still see once you are told where to look.

This one is an infant drawn **from the front**: a large head on top, two arms out to the sides, and the legs bound together so they read as one stroke rather than two. Babies were carried swaddled, and the character kept the bundle.

Write it:

1. the short stroke across the **top**, turning down — the head
2. the **vertical with a hook**, dropping through the middle — the wrapped body
3. the **horizontal** across the middle — the arms

The pitch is **third tone**. The *z* is not the English *z* of *zoo*: it is the *ds* at the end of English *beds*, made with the tongue tip against the teeth.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 子 — head, hooked body, then arms
- *Notice:* two characters now, both three strokes, both once pictures of people. Draw them side by side and compare which parts are curved.

Before you move on

The stroke that runs down the middle carries a hook. What part of the picture is it? (The **wrapped body and legs**.)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

2.7 Two pieces again — and a warning about the story

Both pieces are yours. Draw them side by side:

女子

Script — the assembly

Squeeze them into one block, woman on the left, child on the right:

女 + 子 → 好

好 *hǎo*. Six strokes, three from each half, and again nothing new.

Note what is **different** about this assembly. The first one you built had a meaning half and a sound half. This one has **two meaning halves and no sound half at all** — neither piece sounds like *hǎo*. Both kinds of character are common, and you cannot tell which kind you are holding until you look.

When 女 is squeezed into the left of a block its long crossing bar stops short rather than sweeping past the middle, so as not to collide with what stands beside it. Same piece, narrower posture — the same accommodation you already saw the person component make.

What you've built — and a caution

You will find it said that 好 means *good* **because** a woman with a child is a good thing.

Treat that as a story, not as evidence. It is memorable, it is repeated everywhere, and there is no agreement among specialists that it is what happened — competing accounts read the woman as the sound half in an older pronunciation, or read the pair as a woman *caring for* a child. This book will hand you an etymology when there is a source behind it and tell you plainly when there is not, and this is one of the second kind.

Use the pairing as a **memory hook**, which it genuinely is. Do not file

it as a fact about why the word means what it means.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 好 — the whole left half first, then the whole right half
- *Notice:* the crossing bar on the left half no longer sweeps all the way across. Why not?

Before you move on

Six strokes, two pieces, and you built both pieces yourself. What is the one claim in this lesson you should NOT repeat as fact?

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

Pronunciation & Character Guide

Reference material, never a gate. Every lesson teaches the sounds its own word needs, inline, and links here for anyone who wants the fuller picture. Nobody has to read this page before Lesson 1, and most readers never will.

The ids in each heading are the values a lesson's **sounds**: frontmatter list points at.

Why this page is different from every other track's

In an alphabetic or abugida track, “the sounds you’ll need” is a list of *segments*: this letter is silent, that vowel is long, this consonant is retroflex. Each fact is attached to a letter, and the letter is on the page.

Mandarin adds a second, orthogonally different kind of fact. **Tone** rides on a whole syllable, is not written in the characters at all, and is *phonemic* — it distinguishes words the way a consonant does. A segmental note cannot express it. So this page has two halves: tones first, because they are the part an English speaker has no instinct for, then the segments.

The machine-readable form of the first half lives in the Chinese script reference under **tones** and **toneSandhi**.

Tones

Mandarin has four tones plus a neutral one. Pinyin writes the tone as a mark over the vowel; the characters do not record it anywhere.

The classic demonstration uses one syllable, *ma*:

- **tone-1** — first, high level (contour 55). Held high and flat, one steady note. *mā* — mother.
- **tone-2** — second, rising (35). Climbs from mid to high, like the pitch on a surprised English “huh?”. *má* — hemp.

- **tone-3** — third, dipping (214). Sinks low and creaky; said alone it rises again a little at the end, but in running speech it usually just stays low. *mǎ* — horse.
- **tone-4** — fourth, falling (51). Drops sharply from high to low, like a clipped “No!”. *mà* — to scold.
- **tone-neutral** — unstressed. Short and light, with no mark written at all, pitched by whatever came before it. *ma* — a question particle.

tone-lexical — tone is part of the word

The single fact that matters most, taught in the first lesson: changing the pitch of a Mandarin syllable changes **which word it is**, not how you feel about it. *mā*, *má*, *mǎ* and *mà* are four separate words. English uses pitch for mood and emphasis only, so this is a genuinely new job for an English speaker’s voice.

tone-sandhi-third — two third tones in a row

When a third tone is followed by another third tone, the first is spoken as a rising second tone.

Written **nǐ hǎo**, said **ní hǎo**. Neither the pinyin nor the characters record the change; dictionaries print the citation tone each word carries alone. This is why a reader who trusts only the page mispronounces the commonest greeting in the language.

tone-sandhi-bu — 不 before a fourth tone

不 *bù* is said *bú* when the next syllable has a fourth tone: *bù shì* → *bú shì*. Recorded here for completeness; no Chapter 1 lesson needs it.

Segments

Pinyin is a romanization, not English spelling. A few letters do work you would not guess.

- **pinyin-n** — as in English *no*.
- **pinyin-i** — after most consonants, the *ee* of “see”. (After *z-*, *c-*, *s-*, *zh-*, *ch-*, *sh-*, *r-* it is a different, buzzier vowel; no Chapter 1 word uses those.)

- pinyin-*h* — rougher than English *h*, scraped at the back of the mouth, closer to the *ch* of Scottish *loch* softened.
- pinyin-*ao* — one gliding vowel, the *ow* of “how”. Not two syllables.

The characters themselves

Stroke shapes, components, and stroke order for every character this track has introduced live in Chinese script reference. Unlike the Indic scripts in this curriculum, where stroke order is conventional, Chinese stroke order is a **taught, standardised system** — top before bottom, left before right, horizontal before vertical, outside before inside, and close a box last. That file marks its stroke orders **authoritative** for exactly that reason.

Glossary

This glossary collects every word and phrase taught in the book. Pronunciation appears when it differs from the written form; chapter numbers show where each entry is introduced.

好 *hǎo*

good, well

Introduced in Chapter 1.

你 *nǐ*

you (one person)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

你好 *nǐ hǎo*

hello (literally “you good”)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

Review Questions

Try these without looking ahead. Every prompt comes from the same canonical lesson data as its chapter. Answers begin in the next section.

Chapter 1

1.1 *mā má mǎ mà — one syllable, four words*

How many marked tones does Mandarin have, not counting the neutral one? Type the number as a word.

1.2 你 — “you”, and the first character

Type the Mandarin word, in pinyin with its tone mark, that means ‘you’ (one person).

1.3 好 — “good”, and what replaces etymology here

好 is built from two components. Type the meaning of the one on the left.

1.4 你好 — the greeting, assembled from two things you already have

You have just been introduced to someone. Type the Mandarin greeting in characters.

1.5 *nǐ hǎo — why the greeting is not said the way it is written*

A dictionary prints the greeting as nǐ hǎo. Type it in pinyin the way it is actually spoken.

1.6 好 again — proof, on a character you own, that tone is the word

Read in the falling fourth tone, 好 stops meaning ‘good’. Type its meaning with that tone, in English.

1.7 Practice — greet someone, and be greeted back

Someone greets you with 你好. Type your reply in characters.

Chapter 2

2.1 人 — two strokes, and a person walking

How many strokes does the character for ‘person’ have?

2.2 𠂇 — *the same person, standing sideways*

A character has the narrow upright person component at its left edge. What does that tell you about the word?

2.3 尔 — *a piece that is there for its sound*

When a component is inside a character for its SOUND rather than its meaning, what is it telling you?

2.4 *Putting two pieces together — and reading the result*

In this character, which half points at the MEANING — the left or the right?

2.5 女 — *three strokes, seated*

How many strokes are in the character for 'woman'?

2.6 子 — *three strokes, a child*

What does the three-stroke character with the hooked vertical and a bar across the middle mean?

2.7 *Two pieces again — and a warning about the story*

Does this character have a component that points at its pronunciation?

Answer Key

The first response is the canonical display answer. When a question accepts other authored forms, they appear underneath.

Chapter 1

1.1 *mā má mǎ mà — one syllable, four words*

Answer: four

Also accepted: 4

1.2 你 — “you”, and the first character

Answer: nǐ

Also accepted: nǐ3; nǐ

1.3 好 — “good”, and what replaces etymology here

Answer: woman

Also accepted: female; 女

1.4 你好 — the greeting, assembled from two things you already have

Answer: 你好

Also accepted: nǐ hao; nǐ hǎo; ní hǎo; nihao

1.5 ní hǎo — why the greeting is not said the way it is written

Answer: ní hǎo

Also accepted: nǐ2 hao3; nihao (ní hǎo); ní hao

1.6 好 again — proof, on a character you own, that tone is the word

Answer: to be fond of

Also accepted: to like; like; fond of; be fond of

1.7 Practice — greet someone, and be greeted back

Answer: 你好

Also accepted: nǐ hao; nǐ hǎo; ní hǎo; nihao

Chapter 2

2.1 人 — *two strokes, and a person walking*

Answer: 2

Also accepted: two; 2 strokes; two strokes

2.2 亻 — *the same person, standing sideways*

Answer: it is about a person

Also accepted: person; about a person; it involves a person; people

2.3 尔 — *a piece that is there for its sound*

Answer: roughly how the word is pronounced

Also accepted: the pronunciation; how it sounds; the sound; how to say it

2.4 Putting two pieces together — *and reading the result*

Answer: the left

Also accepted: left; left half; the left half

2.5 女 — *three strokes, seated*

Answer: 3

Also accepted: three; 3 strokes; three strokes

2.6 子 — *three strokes, a child*

Answer: child

Also accepted: a child; baby; kid; child, zi

2.7 Two pieces again — *and a warning about the story*

Answer: no

Also accepted: none; neither; no it does not

Sources for this starter edition

Character shapes, components, and stroke order follow this project's curated character inventory, whose stroke orders are marked authoritative because Chinese stroke order is a standardised taught system rather than a convention. Codepoint and glyph references are to the Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart.

Index

Look up an English meaning, a dedicated language topic, or a chapter topic. Each linked reference opens the chapter where the material is introduced; the focus labels name only explicitly typed lesson sections.

G

good, well 好 (hǎo)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

H

hello (literally “you good”) 你好 (nǐ hǎo)

explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

M

mā má mǎ mà — one syllable, four words

pronunciation topic; explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 1, p. 1

N

Nǐ Hǎo — Hello, Character by Character

chapter topic; Chapter 1, p. 1

nǐ hǎo — why the greeting is not said the way it is written

pronunciation topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 1, p. 1

P

Putting two pieces together — and reading the result

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 11

R

Reading the Greeting — One Piece at a Time

chapter topic; Chapter 2, p. 11

T

Two pieces again — and a warning about the story

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 11

Y

you (one person) 你 (nǐ)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

Other

人 — two strokes, and a person walking

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 11

亻 — the same person, standing sideways

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 11

女 — three strokes, seated

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 11

好 again — proof, on a character you own, that tone is the word

etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

子 — three strokes, a child

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 11

尔 — a piece that is there for its sound

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 11